

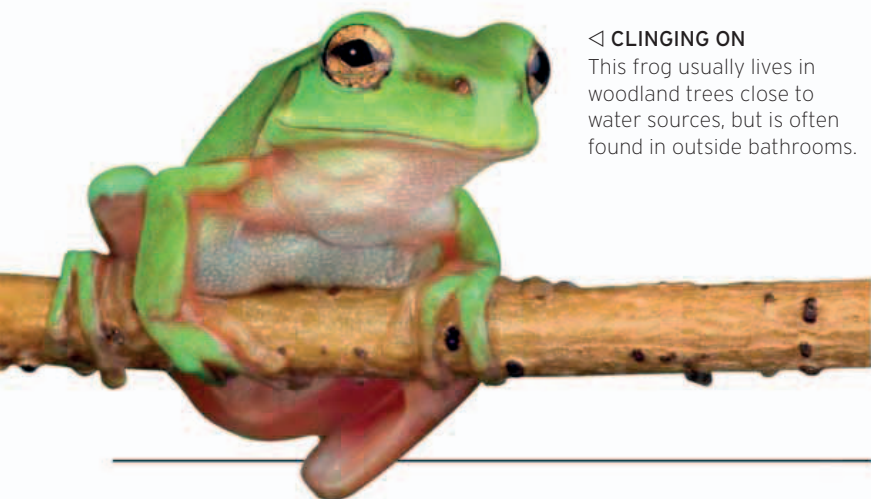
Green tree frog

Litoria caerulea



The large, docile green tree frog is a common sight in the tropical regions of Australia. It spends the day hiding from the sun in damp crevices and emerges at night to hunt. Green tree frogs call all year, but only do so from the ground during the late summer breeding season. Eggs are glued to vegetation in still waters, and the tadpoles transform into adults in six weeks.

- ↔ 2–4 in (5–10 cm)
- ☁ Spring and summer
- ⊗ Common
- 🕷 Insects, mice
- 🏠 S. New Guinea, N. and E. Australia



◁ CLINGING ON

This frog usually lives in woodland trees close to water sources, but is often found in outside bathrooms.

Redback spider

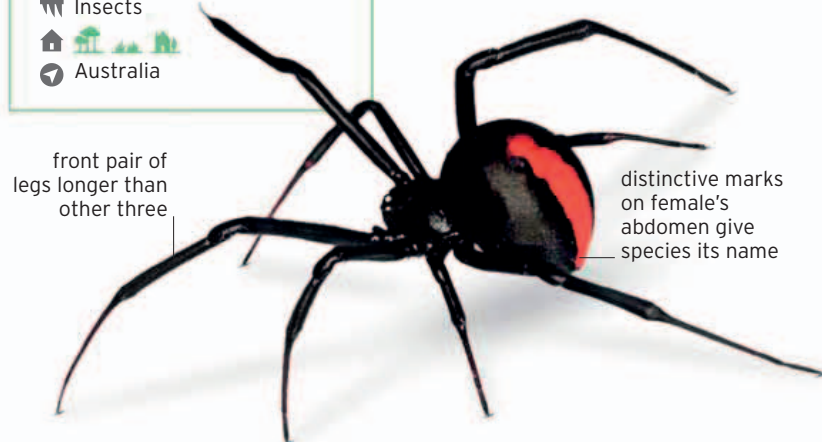
Latrodectus hasseltii

This small but potentially deadly species is one of the highly venomous widow spiders, so named because the female often eats the male after mating. The male is less than a third the size of the female and lurks cautiously on the periphery of her untidy web hoping to steal leftover scraps from the insects she snares.

- ↔ 1/8–3/8 in (0.3–1 cm)
- ⊗ Common
- 🕷 Insects
- 🏠 Australia

▽ KILLER BITE

The female kills her prey with a venom that is powerful enough to endanger humans unless an antivenin is taken.



front pair of legs longer than other three

distinctive marks on female's abdomen give species its name

Green jumping spider

Mopsus mormon

female has dark red and white face mask



This is the largest jumping spider in Australia. Generally, a jumping spider's fangs are too tiny to pierce human skin, but this species can manage it and delivers a painful, although ultimately harmless, bite. The green jumping spider hunts on leaves and stalks for insect prey, ambushing them with a long jump that can be several times the spider's body length. Wherever it goes, the spider lets out a safety line of silk in case it loses its footing. However, jumps are seldom off target thanks to the acute vision afforded by two huge forward-facing eyes, supported by six others elsewhere on the head.

Long courtship

Jumping spiders are cautious of each other, and males must spend a lot of time earning their mate's trust. The male begins by plucking love messages on the female's nest and silk lines and by stroking her abdomen. This courtship generally occurs while the female is still a nonbreeding subadult. The male sets up home next to the female's nest and waits for her to molt into a fully mature form and is ready to mate.

The nest is a crudely woven sheet of silk made on the concave side of long, narrow leaves. It has three sections. The female lives at one end and guards the middle section that will house the eggs. The male builds the far end.

- ↔ 3/8–3/4 in (1.2–1.8 cm)
- ⊗ Common
- 🕷 Insects
- 🏠 N. Australia



N. Australia

▷ SNATCHING A BITE

A large but delicate damselfly succumbs to the swift strike of a green jumping spider camouflaged on a green patch of leaf.

